Chapter 1

Technological and Institutional Roots of Democratic Backsliding in the United States

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In a 2021 report, V-Dem, a research institute at the University of Gothenburg in Sweden, concluded, "Advances in global levels of democracy made over the last 35 years have been wiped out. 72% of the world's population—5.7 billion people—live in autocracies by 2022" (V-Dem 2021. The Economist Intelligence Unit's (EIU's) *Democracy Index* offered similarly pessimistic conclusions. In 2020, 116 of 167 countries recorded a decline in their total democracy score compared with the previous year. The United States held steady as a "flawed democracy," unchanged from 2016 when it lost its "full democracy" status (EIU 2020). By 2022 the gloom hanging over the US had lifted a bit, but the EIU still observed that "social cohesion and consensus have collapsed in recent years as disagreements over an expanding list of issues fuel the country's 'culture wars'" (EIU 2020. The restoration of democratic processes and values was further impeded by Donald Trump's second election in 2024.

What accounts for this crisis of liberal democracy? We address this question by drawing on two distinct yet complementary research literatures. One perspective focuses primarily on the spread of disinformation and the algorithmic amplification of extremist content, while the other addresses the role of institutions and elites in restricting popular participation and promoting extremist ideas. We refer to the first approach as the *technocentric research paradigm* and the second as the *institutionalist research paradigm*. Both literatures provide incomplete yet complementary clues as to why anti-democratic tendencies are more pronounced among parties and voting publics on the right.

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Our goals in this analysis are to 1) describe the logics of both explanations, 2) identify the gaps found in each, and 3) sketch a synthesis. Drawing on the "connective action" model, we argue that hitherto scattered and uncoordinated extremist elements cohere online into quasi-organizations, or what the research literature has referred to as "digitally constituted organizations." Because digital organizational forms tend to be more fluid, nonhierarchical, and leaderless, they also tend to be more resistant to distancing efforts by party leaders. Incorporating digitally constituted organizational forms into institutionalist arguments brings its analytical reach into the digital era as it simultaneously anchors technocentric arguments in broader historical, social, and economic contexts. We begin with a description of what we mean by liberal democracy and democratic backsliding. We then turn to the explanations of how "asymmetrical polarization" on the radical right contributes to democratic decline (Benkler et al. 2018; Bennett et al. 2018). Finally, we develop a more holistic *connective action model of democratic backsliding* that situates extremist digital networks in a broader institutionalist framework that sheds light on the rise of illiberal politics in both institutions and public communication spheres.

Democratic Backsliding

Just what is democratic backsliding? Several often-interchangeable terms are found in discussions of democratic backsliding, including illiberalism and de-democratization, along with references to hybrid regimes, populism, or soft authoritarianism (Collier and Levitsky 1997). For purposes of simplification we understand democratic backsliding as a movement away from liberal democratic ideals via "a series of discrete changes in the rules and informal procedures that shape . . . elections, rights, and accountability" (Lust and Waldner 2015, 2; Waldner and Lust 2018).[1] An opening question posed by political scientist Nancy Bermeo asks: "What kinds of concrete actions transform a regime from one type to another?" (2016, 5). Most scholars agree that rather than a sudden coup d'état, democratic backsliding today is more likely to involve a disjointed series of incremental developments. Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt note that the process of decline comes "slowly, in barely visible steps" (2018, 76–77). Marianne Kneuer refers to "democratic erosion" and offers a model of how these incremental changes

[1] The term "democratic backsliding" is used quite commonly in the research literature. See for example Alemán and Yang (2011), Erdmann (2011), and Finkel et al. (2012).

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occur based on the interplay of agency, opportunity and sequencing (2021). Those changes to formal political institutions and informal practices and norms generally "attenuate the public's ability to make demands on the state without fear of reprisal" (Lust and Waldner 2015, 4).

Through practices such as gerrymandering and other barriers to voting, election fairness is limited without explicitly abolishing universal franchise. When able to govern through minority parties, and appoint judges, or obstruct judicial processes, political leaders become less constrained by accountability norms and threats of possible punishment. Oppositional politicians and parties are demonized, declared "enemies of the people," and in advanced cases of backsliding, threatened with violence, as happened to many honest state election officials following Donald Trump's defeat in the 2020 US presidential election. In extreme cases, opponents may be jailed or murdered (Bermeo 2003, 238; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018, 21–24). Meanwhile, those responsible for such assaults on liberal democratic norms and practices usually cloak their actions in the rhetoric of institutional "reforms" that are defended as restoring "true democracy," which in many cases is a code term for white supremacy or ethnic nationalism.

The institutionalization of minority rule that continues to be advertised as "democratic" requires some mobilization of popular support to establish a veneer of legitimacy. That, in turn, entails various forms of media management. In self-proclaimed illiberal democracies such as Hungary, this may involve complicated schemes of media ownership and content coordination to promote right-wing policies and politicians such as Viktor Orbán. In a less consolidated illiberal system such as the US, more complex media flows involve a mix of broadcast outlets (e.g., Fox news and talk radio), political disinformation sites often funded by wealthy elites (e.g., Breitbart, Daily Caller), and social media platforms that connect and organize publics on the right. The interplay of these different media with institutional actors is important to understand (see Yang 2020). One of the key media-institution interactions that we explore in this chapter involves: 1) the amplification of disinformation, conspiracy, and hate, 2) which makes more extremist candidates viable in elections, and 3) which may result in conservative parties losing control of their own agendas. These dynamics will be discussed in more detail later, but for now the point is that there are important interactions between institutions and communication processes, with each contributing importantly to the transformation of democracies.

What are the benefits of our approach? We hope this synthesis offers a corrective to the sizeable number of books that have looked at institutional

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processes yet have had little to say about media and communication processes in general and social media in particular (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018, Ch. 4). Many of these institutional explanations seem indifferent to the headlines and legislative hearings concerning the threat to democracy posed by social media platforms. The same can be said in reverse about the work done by scholars who focus on the role of media and social technologies in democratic decline (Persily and Tucker 2020). Few factors outside of technology itself can be found in their explanations of democratic decay (Kreiss 2021). More broadly, most of the technocentric literature ignores how the growing audiences for extremist content have been shaped by centuries of racial capitalism, or the catastrophic damage done to rustbelt communities by deindustrialization, and the resulting appeals of politicians to the accompanying crises of meaning and purpose visited upon millions of people (Robinson 2020; Case and Deaton 2020).

We begin with a review of technocentric explanations, highlighting some of the gaps that can be filled by institutionalist approaches.

Technocentric Approaches to Asymmetrical Polarization and Democratic Backsliding

Following the 2016 Brexit referendum in the United Kingdom and the presidential election in the United States, many observers pointed to the role of social technologies as the chief cause of these unexpected outcomes. Soon a broad consensus formed around the idea that a new and largely unexpected crisis of democracy had emerged, one principally fueled by social media platforms. "It seemed possible," noted Yascha Mounk (2018), "that the rise of digital technology, and the concomitant spread of essentially costless communication, have set up a direct clash between two of our most cherished values: freedom of speech and the stability of our political system." Resting on an intuitive logic, the technocentric argument has two parts.

First is the claim that the priorities of the social media behemoths are shaped not by a sense of collective civic responsibility or by a regard for democratic principles but by an insatiable appetite for financial growth and market domination, often fueled by the circulation of extremist content. The platforms rest on a business model that Shoshana Zuboff (2019, 8) terms "surveillance capitalism." She likens it to a manufacturing process, one

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beginning with the extraction of raw materials, arguing that a platform "unilaterally claims human experience as free raw material for translation into behavioral data, which become proprietary behavioral surplus." Predictions of future behaviors are then packaged and sold on a "behavior futures market" to other corporations for use in targeted marketing campaigns (Zuboff 2019, 7). To extract behavioral surplus, user attention must remain fixed on digital content, and nothing holds attention like algorithmically amplified fear and loathing. Surveillance capitalism is fueled by extremist content.

This logic is evident in the internal Facebook documents provided to news organizations and the US Securities and Exchange Commission in the fall of 2021 by whistleblower Frances Haugen (Horwitz 2021). They show that Facebook employees raised concerns internally about the spurious "Stop the Steal" content spread by Trump supporters both before and after the 2020 election. A Facebook data scientist discovered that as much as 10% of all US political views on the platform during the week after the election contained the false claim that the election was fraudulent (Mac and Frenkel 2021). Facebook also knew that extremist movements and groups on its site were "trying to polarize American voters before the election" (Mac and Frenkel 2021). Haugen made it clear that Facebook executives were fully aware of just how serious a problem algorithmic amplification of polarizing content was during the election.

A second part of the technocentric research paradigm emerges from the cognitive turn in political science in the closing decades of the twentieth century (Freelon and Wells 2020, 149). Here the focus is on the limitations of human information processing and the resulting susceptibility to emotionally soothing disinformation (Porter and Wood 2019). Citizens are understood to be pulled between conflicting motivations (Taber and Lodge 2006). On the one hand, are accuracy goals that lead individuals to seek out and carefully consider relevant evidence to reach factually sound conclusions (Baumeister and Newman 1994; Fiske and Taylor 1991). On the other hand, partisan goals involve motivations to seek out confirming information and to reason in support of prior beliefs (Kruglanski and Webster 1996; Kunda 1987, 1990; Bakshy et al. 2015; for a more recent treatment of this conclusion, see Brady et al. 2017; for a contrary perspective, see Boxell et al. 2017). Protecting existing beliefs rather than accuracy is the goal.

According to this understanding of the problem, a recursive downward spiral of democratic dysfunction is triggered by algorithmically amplified content that encourages selective exposure through curated newsfeeds

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(Thaler 2021; Pennycook and Rand 2021). This leads to greater political polarization, which opens space for yet more disinformation, which then exacerbates polarization, and so forth. In this environment, ideologically temperate citizens are put off by highly polarized politics, leaving the political arena to divisive extremist voices. Rumors, innuendo, and conspiracy theories are ratcheted up in a reinforcement loop among online and cable news personalities and prominent political officials.

Layered over this dynamic is the disruptive influence of foreign actors who leverage social media affordances to their own political advantage (Sanovich 2018; Harold et al. 2021). For example, a 2023 study found that Russian disinformation concerning its invasion of Ukraine parroted rhetorical themes common with the American far right in an effort to undermine public support for US and NATO military aid to Ukraine. Onetime Fox on-air personality Tucker Carlson, far-right podcaster Steve Bannon, and several Republican congressional representatives all pushed the false narrative that Russia and Russian President Vladimir Putin were allies in backing traditional values and religion in the fight against "woke" ideas (Stone 2023).

This account describes the underlying logic of much of the backsliding-as-a-technology-problem (see Freelon and Wells 2020; Tucker et al. 2018; Wooley and Guilbeault 2017; Tsfati et al. 2020; and Boulianne 2015). It offers an elegant and intuitively logical explanation of polarization and democratic backsliding. Yet we believe it is also incomplete, especially in its inattentiveness to existing social and institutional power structures.

Institutional and Political Contexts of Disinformation and Democratic Disruption

Explanations that focus on the algorithmic amplification of polarizing content often neglect the erosion of trust in democratic institutions by media and political organizations that aim to undermine authoritative claims about shared realities. Reliance on cognitive models of *individual* radicalization creates blind spots to social and historical context. That erosion of trust in political institutions in the US began long before the advent of social media (Pew Research Center 2015). Decades of attacks on trusted public institutions and scientific authorities by the Republican Party and affiliated political, media, and business groups have created openings for the spread of disinformation (Bennett and Livingston 2018, 2020). Ironically, those

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attacks on shared authority and a national identity grounded in tolerance kindled a rebirth of white nationalism which aided the takeover of the GOP by Trump and his Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement. The Stop the Steal campaign following Trump's 2020 election loss has opened the path to even greater erosions of voting rights, including allowing partisan certification of elections in a number of Republican states. The resulting loss of trust in elections has added to political polarization and the spread of disinformation to justify the corruption of public institutions and protections. As Rachel Kuo and Alice Marwick observe, framing these problems only in technological terms "disconnects disinformation from the broader politics of knowledge production and systems of power that undergird it" (2021). In their view, purely technological solutions are "curiously depoliticized, framed as 'polluting' or 'infecting' an otherwise healthy information ecosystem" (2021, 1).

Furthermore, when understood mainly as a technnological or media problem, technical solutions are given priority, including AI solutions for content moderation, better bot detection, remedial citizen literacy programs, and fact-checking to clean up around the edges of an otherwise healthy information environment. Technical problems call for technical solutions. Yet as we have noted elsewhere, the current "information disorder" is rooted in the physical world where money and influence undermine the legitimacy of authoritative institutions. Or as Daniel Kreiss observes, "It is impossible to understand social media and democracy without accounting for the historical, racial, and institutional contexts that gave formative shape to our present politics, for they explain why disinformation and polarization take the specific forms they do" (Kreiss 2021, 5). With the technocentric approach, political, historical, economic, and social factors recede into the background (Kreiss and Reddi 2021).

Nor does the technocentric research paradigm account for the role of political organizations and operatives such as Robert Mercer and his daughter Rebekah as financial backers of the Breitbart political propaganda site, the Cambridge Analytica behavioral engineering company, and later, the far-right–friendly Parler social media platform that served as a coordinating platform for the January 6th insurrection, and housed a collection of hundreds of videos from participants documenting the events (Gold 2017; Lerman 2021). Nor do technocentric approaches account for a half-century of free market libertarian attacks on the credibility of scientific findings that signaled the need for market regulation or protections for public health

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and the environment. With billions of dollars spent over three decades, the Koch network has created hundreds of think tanks, free market university research programs, and a host of grassroots and astroturf social movements, and helped to refashion the Tea Party into a GOP power base to disrupt governance, defeat the regulatory state, and limit challenges to white elite power structures (Mayer 2016; Leonard 2019; Maclean 2017; for the Tea Party see Parker and Barreto 2013). To advance such an illiberal agenda, many long-known facts, such as the relationship between burning hydrocarbons and climate change, had to be dismissed and the scientists who produced such studies discredited (Powell 2011). Our post–fact era started well before Mark Zuckerberg created the precursor to Facebook in his Harvard dorm room. Our point is that *the relationships between disruptive technologies and historical patterns of institutional corruption need to be better understood and addressed*. Beyond offering more complete explanations of why the US is on an illiberal path, the interactions between politics, institutions, and communication may shed light on where that path may lead. As noted earlier, various post-democratic forms have emerged, with historical cases displaying different combinations of ethnic nationalism, crony capitalism, authoritarianism, fascism, violence, and anarchy. We pick up these national variations in the conclusion.

To advance our understanding of contemporary threats to democracy, at least one more question that must be addressed. Why is most of this disinformation and institutional corruption coming from the right? Intuitive understandings may suggest that there are more reactionary economic interests with more money driving these attacks on democracy. In addition, an inspection of right-wing movements around the world suggests that large publics are reacting against perceived challenges to their privileged statuses in society, as racial, religious, and marginalized gender identity groups assert democratic rights (Parker 2021). However, there remains a piecemeal quality to explaining the convergence of elite interests, public resentments, and disinformation, resulting from different varieties of democratic backsliding in different societies. *What overarching brokerage mechanisms or institutional processes organize this convergence of conservative business interests, disinformation, and popular unrest?* We propose that many of these elements of democratic backsliding have come together—with different configurations in different polities—based on the ways in which conservative political parties try to manage the dilemma of how to maximize their electoral success while advancing elitist and often unpopular economic agendas.

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How Did We Get Here? Updating the Conservative Dilemma

What accounts for such transformations of political parties, and the resulting erosion of democratic institutions such as election integrity processes, independent press organizations and court systems? In *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy*, Daniel Ziblatt (2017) argues that sustaining liberal democracy in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Europe depended on the nature of conservative party efforts to dodge growing public demands for fairer and more equitable distributions of power and resources. As the scope of suffrage and the power of social movements grew, center-right parties faced what Ziblatt calls a *conservative dilemma*. To win elections, conservative parties must appeal to the working and middle classes while also remaining loyal to the economic elites with whom they are most closely aligned. How a party navigates this dilemma may determine both its political fate and its impact on democracy. In some of the cases he examines, compromises were reached, and democracy was sustained; in other cases, democracy was crushed as public passions were directed to distractive nationalism, racism, and xenophobia. The types of issues a party uses to mobilize support from nonelites, along with the stability of its relationships with allied "surrogate" civil society, business, and media organizations shapes the outcome.

Applying this model to the US Republican Party, Jacob Hacker and Paul Pierson argue that "other kinds of organizations—single-issue groups, cultural institutions such as churches, and certain kinds of media outlets" become *party surrogates*: "These organizations can focus on building strong emotional bonds with citizens and tapping shared identities" (2020, 23). Both in Ziblatt's historical analysis and in Hacker and Pierson's contemporary US case, party surrogates are understood in terms of conventional bureaucratic organizations. For example, Ziblatt notes the role of the Primrose League, a civic organization that served as a surrogate of the British Conservative Party in the early twentieth century by appealing to nonelites with a focus on opposition to Irish independence and support for the Anglican Church and the monarchy. These *cross-cutting issues* mobilized support across class divides. In the US, traditional surrogates include Christian evangelical churches, gun rights organizations, anti-abortion groups, and conservative media outlets like *National Review*, and more recently, Fox News and conservative talk radio (Hemmer 2016; Kruse 2015).

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While surrogate organizations can help resolve the conservative party dilemma, they also present risks. Most concerning are cases where the interests of surrogates are at odds with party priorities, resulting in usurping organizational identity and ideological coherence. For example, in a desire for better ratings, an aligned media organization, such as Fox News, might appeal to key audience demographics by taking positions on issues or promoting politicians that spread destabilizing extremist rhetoric on immigration, minority gender identities, non-Christian religious sects, or "white replacement" theories. The sworn testimony provided by Fox News personalities, and Rupert Murdoch himself, in the Dominion Voting defamation case underscored that Fox News was more interested in preserving its market share among conservative viewers than it was in preserving trust in US elections. According to their private message exchanges, Sean Hannity, Tucker Carlson, and Laura Ingraham all expressed doubts about the "Stop the Steal" narrative, with Carlson at one point writing, "Sidney Powell is lying." Powell, of course, was a quasi-official member of Trump's legal team following his election loss. Still, despite the private misgivings, all Fox hosts continued to air the election fraud narrative (Ellison and Gardner 2023). When activated by opportunistic politicians, political foundations and interest groups, or media organizations, extremist factions represent votes for or against a conservative party. At the same time, appealing to such elements may risk electing more extreme representatives who threaten party agendas and stability. Surrogate organizations can be a mixed blessing. Social technologies, we argue, exacerbate the tendency toward party boundary maintenance challenges and the pull toward illiberalism.

Many extremist groups are typically scattered and poorly organized, and thus present more challenging problems to mobilize than traditional organizations such as churches. However, digital media platforms (both social media and political information sites) enable once fragmented extremist networks to grow and find each other. The ease of communicating with formerly marginalized fringe elements may attract opportunistic politicians, media sites, and political organizations that aim to mobilize them into voting blocks. When scattered extremists become organized into more coherent publics, conservative parties risk becoming destabilized and radicalized.

In sum, traditional approaches to the conservative dilemma in the US have focused mainly on formal interest organizations such as conventional

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religious groups, anti-abortion movements, or gun rights lobbies, along with more recent developments such as how Koch political organizations helped add the Tea Party to the Republican mix (Skocpol and Williamson 2016). What we would like to add is the emergence of increasingly organized grassroots *online* extremist factions that now compete with traditional surrogate groups for control of the party and its political agenda, with even greater disruptions to larger democratic processes. In effort to understand how all of this happened in a seemingly short time, we address two questions:

> First, what developments in the Republican Party's historic quest for power created conditions that opened the party to losing control over its own surrogates, resulting in rapid political transformation?
>
> Second, what communication and institutional conditions enabled once fringe elements to become organized enough to reshape the fortunes of the party and accelerate the threat to core democratic institutions such as election processes?

Undermining Institutional Authority: The Historical Conservative Quest for Power

In 1964, Lyndon Johnson defeated Republican Barry Goldwater in one of the greatest landside victories in American political history. Not only did Johnson trounce Goldwater, but the Democratic Party also picked up 37 seats in the House of Representatives and two seats in the Senate, thereby capturing supermajorities in both chambers. After 1964 election, the GOP found itself in a position not unlike that of the British Conservative Party in 1906. Following the party's disastrous defeat in the 1906 Parliamentary elections, the Liberal-led government—holding 397 seats to the Conservative Party's 156—pioneered Britain's transformation into a modern welfare state (Wikipedia n.d.). The Liberal government also enacted an aggressive tax program aimed at the rich and landed aristocracy (Ziblatt 2017, 143). It was a bold frontal assault on the old order.

In response, Conservative Party leaders adopted a "combative, hard-edged and distinctly right-wing profile because the *party fell into the grips of its activist base*" (Ziblatt 2017, 143 Emphasis added). According to one historian's account, the British Conservative Party appeared "prepared to

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defy the laws and legislature of the land to resort to extra-parliamentary and nonconstitutional means, to preach violence and to practice it if needs be, and even to support rebellion and risk civil war, in an attempt to recover their position" (Cannadine 1999, 517). A similar outcome took longer to realize in the US, as the GOP first succeeded in adding less extreme surrogate groups who helped elect Ronald Reagan in the 1980s. However, an economic crisis and the election of a Black president in 2008 helped mobilize a racist Tea Party, followed by the election of Donald Trump in 2016 who brought even more extremist elements into the party (Parker and Barreto 2013).

The long road to Republican extremism began with the shock to the core party constituency of pro-free enterprise conservatives after 1964 when Johnson's Great Society programs turned federal government into an engine of renewal and progress for poor people, and especially for subjugated people of color. Johnson's signing of the Civil Rights Act in 1964 outlawed discrimination based on race, color, religion, gender, or national origin pushed unwanted change on the centuries-old racial caste system of the South (Civil Rights Act 1964). The Civil Rights Act also prohibited unequal application of voter registration requirements, and racial segregation in schools, employment, and public spaces. The Voting Rights Act the following year was intended to end Jim Crow impediments to African American voting rights. Of course, it wasn't until the heroic actions of those in the civil rights movement—who forced segregationist compliance with the law by putting their own bodies on the line—did the new laws begin to have the intended effects (Branch 1988). Meanwhile, the environmental, women's rights, and sexual rights movements, among others, added demands that government act to right grievous social and economic inequality and threats to life on the planet.

How did the GOP respond to these challenges? Following the logic of Ziblatt's conservative dilemma model, Hacker and Pierson (2020) review two GOP responses to the conservative dilemma: 1) voter suppression and manipulation of institutional rules to facilitate GOP minority control of state and national government; and 2) offering symbolic (e.g., moral, religious, and racial) appeals to distract from growing economic disparity issues. Before turning to our synthesis of the institutionalist and technocentric models of democratic backsliding, we review Hacker and Pierson's argument and then turn to a discussion of where it falls short. Although they offer a compelling explanation of the modern GOP's response to the conservative

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dilemma, their understanding of the nature of party organizational surrogates in the digital age causes problems for their overall analysis. This oversight leads them to underestimate the true depth of the threat posed to liberal democracy by the conservative dilemma in the US.

Voter Suppression

Various mechanisms of voter suppression continue to be the most democratically destructive GOP tactics for addressing the conservative dilemma, though of course Republican disinformation campaigns frame them in terms of election integrity. There is, however, no sound evidence in support of Republican claims about voter fraud (Levitt 2007; Bush 2020). Instead, "anti-fraud" measures are thinly disguised efforts to *suppress* voter participation, especially participation by the poor and people of color, just as poll taxes and literacy tests did in the Jim Crow era (Daniels 2020). Putting hurdles before Black people, poor people, and Democratic voters more generally becomes a necessary supplement when the collection of surrogate organizations fails to deliver needed majorities. The level of open rigging of elections has become blatant. Of course, gerrymandering has remained a mainstay of voter suppression tactics, creating minority party rule in a number of states (Tausanovitch and Root 2020). In addition, many states have reduced the number of polling places in Democratic districts, particularly in African American and Latinx neighborhoods (Cohen 2020). In some states, photo identification requirements for voters accept gun club membership cards but not student IDs Lessig 2021). When a lawyer for the Republican National Committee was asked by Trump appointed conservative Supreme Court Justice Amy Coney Barrett why his party opposed legislation enabling more people to vote, his reply was because it "puts us at a competitive disadvantage" (Lessig 2021).

As Hacker and Pierson (2020) note, these many forms of voter suppression have become key pillars of GOP efforts to address the conservative dilemma. Fundamentally, it is an effort to undermine democracy. Voter suppression measures require the spread of growing volumes of disinformation to maintain the illusion of plausibility. Thus, voter suppression becomes "election integrity," and the partisan control of election certification is justified as a necessary response to election theft by the opposition (Stanley-Becker 2020). Disinformation in support of institutional

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corruption undermines popular comprehension of the problems, draws extremist support for dissembling politicians, and speeds the path of democratic decline.

Issue Distraction

The second traditional GOP response to its conservative dilemma involves efforts to activate social divisions through noneconomic issues:

> Outflanked by the left on economic issues, *their survival depended on introducing or highlighting other social divisions.* And these divisions couldn't be trivial or temporary; they had to be strong enough to attract durable political support from the working and middle classes. In modern societies, the list of such "cleavages" is short, and their history unpleasant. There are racial, ethnic, and religious divisions. There is the call of nationalism or foreign military adventures. There are sectional loyalties. There is opposition to immigration. In short, there is a set of noneconomic issues—many racially tinged, all involving strong identities and strong emotions—that draw a sharp line between "us" and "them." (Hacker and Pierson 2020, 22, emphasis added)

Voter suppression and distraction are key pillars of Hacker and Pierson's analysis of how the Republican Party has responded to the conservative dilemma. However, we believe that there is another factor that adds an important element of volatility to these attacks on democracy—a development that makes it hard to predict just what form of rule might emerge following the possible demise of democratic governance in the United States. This critical element in the contemporary conservative dilemma involves expanding our understanding of what constitutes a surrogate organization in the digital age. In particular, we suggest that unlike traditional interest organizations or civil society surrogates, we now witness organized networks of formerly marginalized extremist groups that threaten anarchy, possibly followed by authoritarian consolidation. Unlike surrogates that align with parties as brokers for their issue agendas, digitally networked alignments of extremist, and potentially violent factions, can threaten party coherence and political order. *When such elements are cued by a combination of politicians inside parties, along with outside organizations, political operatives*

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and media sites, a conservative party like the Republicans may well lose control of its own agenda and become an even more serious threat to democracy. The rise of such organized extremism, and its central role in Trump's MAGA movement, bring us to our next question: How do communication processes enable the formation of digitally networked surrogate organizations that challenge the identity and control of the Republican Party itself?

Communication and the Organization of Networked Extremism

Hacker and Pierson (2020) generally overlook the effects of digital technology on both organizational forms and behavior. Manuel DeLanda (2006), Andrew Chadwick (2013), W. Lance Bennett and Alexandra Segerberg (2013), and Daniel Kreiss (2021a), among others, have noted that organizational forms based on digital platforms are markedly different from conventional organizations. These new forms can be fluid and composed of diverse networks connected around shared memes such as "stop the steal" or "deep state" conspiracies. These assemblages may be in constant flux and operate both online and offline, much as QAnon shifts issue focus and alignments with other groups, appears in diverse protests, and takes different transnational forms.

In *The Logic of Connective Action*, Lance Bennett and Alexandra Segerberg (2013) speak of *communication as organizatio*n, whereas other scholars speak of hybrid organizations and digitally enabled organizations (Chadwick 2013; Livingston and Walter-Drop 2013). These terms point to the idea that social media platforms can enable new organizational forms. As Bennett and Segerberg note:

> Communication is often much more than a means of exchanging information and forming impressions, or an instrument for sending updates and instructions to followers. Communication routines can, under some conditions, create patterned relationships among people that lend organization and structure to many aspects of social life. As digital media become more prominent in contemporary contention, they too help to configure the protest space and the action that develops within it. Ultimately, technology-enabled networks may become dynamic organizations in their own right. (2013, 289, emphasis added)

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Bennett and Segerberg array different organizational forms along a continuum anchored at one end by conventional organizations with buildings, staff, and budgets, and at the other, by technology enabled networked organizations with few of the outward trappings of more traditional bureaucracy. When Hacker and Pierson speak of surrogate organizations, they limit their understanding to conventional organizations with staff filling defined roles in a hierarchical bureaucratic structure. In failing to take theoretical account of digitally networked organizations, they underestimate the danger to democracy presented by a fracturing GOP that was transformed in a shockingly short time through interactions among social media networks, political information sites, reactionary organizations and foundations, and cues from opportunistic politicians inside the party itself. As a result, QAnon, the Boogaloo Bois, the Proud Boys, Christian white nationalist organizations, and dozens of other factions of the MAGA movement became surrogates of the Republican Party. Many Republicans might deny or resist this characterization, but this is exactly what we mean by digital surrogates creating new organizational boundary problems.

Much of the existing literature on connective action has focused on progressive or left-wing social movements. It is important to note that the kind of "asymmetrical polarization" that distinguishes the far left from the far right in many democracies reflects a different collection of political values and organizational styles that have become characteristics of the contemporary left. There have, of course, been impressive examples of massive mobilizations on the left based largely on forms of technology enabled organization. For example, the Occupy Wall Street protest networks in 2011–2012 became densely organized through processes of sharing memes that affirmed common identities (e.g., "We Are the 99%"), while crowds circulated and curated various connective resources such as protest tactics and advice on what to do when arrested. Those patterns of coordinated communication produced familiar organizational capacities such as making and sharing agendas, planning, taking action, and responding to external threats and opportunities (see Bennett et al. 2014).

Though impressive in many ways, these digitally networked organizations that operate outside of the conventional bureaucratic left of labor movements and environmental NGOs, tend to be fluid, relatively nonhierarchical, and difficult to sustain. Key factors contributing to the relative lack of stable movement and party formation on the technology-enabled left include

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diminished confidence in parties, and growing dissatisfaction with traditional movement organization based in ideology, collective identity, and conventional leadership. As a result, a continuing pattern of mobilization on the left involves creative uses of technologically to enable sometimes massive, but generally short-lived, protests and deliberative gatherings centered around principles of diversity, inclusion, and direct democracy (see Bennett et al. 2018).

Before their incorporation into the MAGA movement with its connection to the GOP, many fringe networks on the far right were also located at the "technology enabled" end of the Bennett and Segerberg organization continuum. The list of such organizations includes white nationalist and anti-immigrant groups, neo-Nazis, armed militias such as the Boogaloo Bois and the Proud Boys, wellness and anti-vaccination communities, patriarchal white male Christian identity organizations such as the Promise Keepers, various Tea Party remnants, conspiracy networks such as QAnon and the anti-globalists, and Stop the Steal activists, among other factions. A finer grained look reveals hundreds, if not thousands, of formerly scattered groups that have now become more connected to Republican Party politics. For example, a 2019 Southern Poverty Law Center report identified 576 extremist antigovernment organizations. By the fateful election of 2020, and the subsequent assault on the US Capitol to stop government officials from certifying the election, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, Reddit, Pinterest, Instagram, and Telegram, among others, had become go-to organizational platforms for these groups.

What accounts for this shift toward greater coherence in movement organization on the right? In part, the smaller number of common core values such as racism, nationalism, and religion, makes common cause easier to create, in contrast with the proliferation of causes and identity politics on the left. An even more important explanation for the rapid organization of right-wing extremism is that factions on the right have received support from a variety of well-resourced political and media organizations (Mac and Lerer 2022; Derysh 2021).

The organizational transformation of right-wing extremism conforms to what Bennett and Segerberg call "organizationally enabled" networks which fall along the middle range of their continuum, in between conventional hierarchical organizations and more technology enabled distributed organizations. What accounts for this?

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The scale and stability of right-wing networked organizations has been enabled by a mix of a) political media sites, b) tax exempt nonprofit political organizations, c) political operatives, and d) elected leaders, all promoting e) spreadable memes, narratives, and disinformation that connect different networks. After briefly describing these elements of organizationally enabled political surrogate networks, we will show how the various coordinating mechanisms, listed above, contributed to the January 6th insurrection at the US Capitol. That action, along with the behind the scenes plotting by Trump and his allies, constitutes a failed coup attempt. In the limited space here, we can only sketch brief illustrations of each type of organizational mechanism.

Political Media Sites

Media organizations have been instrumental in channeling messaging to and from audiences anchored in GOP surrogate organizations. In earlier years, talk radio and conservative television networks such as Fox News, communicated largely with traditional GOP surrogates such as evangelical Christian churches, family values NGOs, and gun rights groups. More recently, the appeals have included more extremist messages, as when Fox News personalities such as Tucker Carlson played up white replacement narratives already circulating in international radical right networks (Chait 2021). Such expansion of the bounds of conventional Republican ideas suggests that during the Trump years, Fox departed from its loyalty to mainstream party leadership. For example, hosts on Fox News such as Sean Hannity, Laura Ingram, and Tucker Carlson were once formerly more aligned with traditional GOP surrogates. However, their roles changed after Trump was elected and he became a celebrity guest on their programs. Their discussions on various issues such as trade, public health disinformation during the COVID-19 pandemic, and election integrity, moved those issues away from former GOP centers of gravity once established by party leadership and neoliberal surrogate organizations created by Charles Koch.

After the news side of Fox affirmed that Joe Biden had won the 2020 election, Trump directed the attention of his followers to other media organizations such as *One America News Network*, which held White House press credentials as a Trump administration surrogate, pushing the boundaries of the GOP public even farther to the extreme. However, after being taken down from Twitter and Facebook (until 2023), and failing with his

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own platform, Trump was soon back on Fox as his coterie of commentators gave him a platform to spread the Big Lie about the stolen election to a large audience.

Tax Exempt Political Nonprofits

Organizations funded by wealthy reactionaries also contribute resources, infrastructure and direction to the radical fringe. For example, former US Education Secretary Betsy DeVos's family funds the Michigan Freedom Fund and other far-right organizations in the Michigan Conservative Coalition (Wilson 2020). Those political organizations helped scattered local groups organize against the stay-at-home order in Michigan during the early days of the COVID pandemic. Those "Unlock Michigan" protests brought the far-right Proud Boys hate group and other Confederate flag-waving activists to the Michigan State House, and some militia members entered the Capitol carrying semiautomatic weapons. There were even calls to assassinate the governor of Michigan, and the FBI uncovered a plot to kidnap her and put her on trial. Eventually, the far-right militia members involved in the plot were given long prison sentences (Smith 2022). The DeVos family have also been principal contributors to the Koch network of more conventional Republican surrogate organizations (Mayer 2016, 205). The composition and organization of the Michigan occupation was seen by some observers as a dress rehearsal for the insurrection at the US Capitol on January 6, 2021 (Gray 2021).

Political Operatives

The "inside game" to overturn the election and install Trump as president was headed up by a coterie of Trump operatives and advisors who gathered in what they termed a "command center" at the Willard Hotel in the heart of Washington and communicated with White House officials, including the president (Alemany et al. 2021). Those operatives included Trump advisor and former Breitbart publisher Steve Bannon; Rudy Giuliani, Trump's personal lawyer and tireless advocate for overturning the election; and attorney John Eastman, who developed a legal theory that Vice President Mike Pence could stop the congressional certification of state electoral votes and either invite key states to select slates of electors favorable

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to Trump, or remand the decision to the House of Representatives, which had a majority of Republican states. In addition, Bannon used his popular *War Room* podcast to fuel doubt about the election results and to preview the events of January 6 with the promise that "all hell is going to break loose" (Neidig 2022).

Another member of the Willard command center was long-time Republican "dirty trickster" and Trump advisor Roger Stone, who was involved in staging the so-called Brooks Brothers riot when well-dressed Republican staffers disrupted the vote recount in Miami-Dade County Florida during the 2000 election. Stopping the count threw the outcome into the courts, where Bush was eventually declared the Florida winner in a 5–4 vote of the US Supreme Court, a decision that gave Bush enough electoral votes to make him president. Stone later coined the "Stop the Steal" meme ahead of the 2016 election, based on his assumption that Trump would lose, and that the election could be challenged. Stone's rallying cry was finally activated in 2020 and used by other political operatives and organizations to mobilize a number of state level protests leading up to the January 6th Capitol insurrection—all creating the appearance of public support for the coup attempt.

Cueing and Recognition by Elected Leaders

Consider the improbable rise of QAnon to national and international prominence. Several of the chapters in this volume document the rise and importance of the conspiracy in US and even German politics. A mysterious Q who claimed to be a high government official with Q-level security clearance alerted followers on 4chan that a ring of Democratic politicians and Hollywood elites were engaging in Satanic rites of child sex trafficking and cannibalism and suggesting that Donald Trump would save the children with a massive sting operation called "The Storm." Posts from Q appeared in late 2017, initially expanding upon the "Pizzagate" conspiracy theory from the 2016 election claiming that Democratic candidate Hillary Clinton and other top Democratic Party officials were conducting a demonic child sex trafficking operation from the (in reality, nonexistent) basement of a Washington pizza restaurant.

The updated pronouncements of Q were soon reposted on different platforms, and followers with Q signs and paraphernalia began showing up at Republican election rallies in 2018. During the 2020 presidential

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campaign, Trump disavowed knowing much about Q or QAnon, but he pledged to do what he could to save the children. More importantly, he recognized the movement during the 2020 campaign through his tweets. Trump retweeted at least 90 posts from 49 different QAnon conspiracy accounts, despite warnings from the Federal Bureau of Investigation that the network was "a potential source of domestic terrorism after several people radicalized by QAnon had been charged with crimes, ranging from attempted kidnapping to murder, all inspired by the conspiracy theory" (Nguyen 2020).

QAnon quickly gained visibility and entered the physical world through paraphernalia such as signs and shirts found at GOP rallies, and through activists such as the infamous Q shaman who became a signal player in the invasion of the US Capitol. Adherents to this and other conspiracy theories were elected to the US House of Representatives (Breland 2020). With high levels of social media engagement, legacy media attention, and recognition from politicians, the movement grew and intersected with other, once fringe, surrogate groups. Q signs soon appeared at right-wing rallies in Europe.

Memes, Narrative Elements, and Disinformation as Networking Mechanisms

With the help of various network brokers such as well-funded political organizations, operatives, media sites and elected politicians, once-isolated extremist networks began to join with more traditional Republican Party surrogates, such as anti-abortion groups and evangelical church organizations, around themes of patriotism and white Christian nationalism (Stewart 2019; Du Mez 2020; Gorski and Perry 2022). A collection of now familiar memes ("Stop the Steal," "Make America Great Again," "Build the Wall," "Lock Her Up") served as rallying cries that traveled across network boundaries to create common emotional bonds that united a large and volatile MAGA movement.

The themes that travel across different extremist networks can be cued top-down by media, politicians, political organizations, and operatives, but they can also travel from the bottom-up as networks generate their own content that various enabling actors may pick up and send back to confer recognition. This is essentially what Kate Starbird describes in Chapter 2 of this volume. Such interactive framing represents an organizational form that is difficult to command or control centrally. Hence the spiral of extremism.

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Perhaps the biggest of many lies and deceptions of the Trump era was the claim that the election was stolen. That repeatedly falsified claim turned into a highly useful and disruptive mythology for many Republican voters. The widespread belief in the theft of the election, along with the mobilization of the Stop the Steal movement, would not have happened without the above elements working together to spread the disinformation, coordinate various action networks, and bring the resulting surrogates into the Republican Party. The Big Lie that the 2020 election was stolen later became the cover story for many state-level efforts to further limit voter participation, and even to grant control over election certification to Republican controlled state legislatures. These feedback loops have pushed the party's efforts to rig elections well beyond the bounds of decorum and democratic plausibility of earlier institutional corruption initiatives outlined by Hacker and Pierson and others.

The Fate of American Democracy and Future of the Republican Party

The density and extremism of the resulting MAGA movement organization that has changed the Republican Party is impressive. Consider just one brief phase of the Stop the Steal mobilization. A study by *Just Security* at New York University found that between September 1, 2020 and February 2, 2021 there were over 8,200 articles containing variations on the keywords "Stop the Steal":

> Those articles garnered more than 70,000,000 engagements on different platforms; more than 43.5 million of those engagements were registered in December 2020 alone. More than 83 percent (58.5 million) of total engagements were registered on YouTube videos, which appeared on multiple platforms, including Facebook, Twitter, Pinterest, and Reddit. YouTube videos containing "Stop the Steal" or "#StopTheSteal" garnered 21,267,165 views, 863,151 likes, and 34,091 dislikes in the time period analyzed." (Atlantic Council DFRLab 2021)

This networked organization linked grassroots citizens with media hubs, political organizations, and elected Republican officials—all joined in sharing convenient myths and disinformation. As a result, a collection of once isolated extremist factions has taken its place alongside traditional surrogate organizations to impact the identity and electoral future of the Republican

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Party. As Sidney Tarrow (2021) has observed, when extremism develops into organized movements, those movements can take over parties, and in the case of the MAGA movement, push a conservative party into illiberal territory. This observation is aligned with the logic of Ziblatt's conservative dilemma model.

To put it mildly, this unfortunate outcome of the conservative dilemma in the US can be thought of as a failure of institutional gatekeeping. As Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt (2018, 36) argue, "protection against would-be authoritarians has not been (found in) Americans firm commitment to democracy but, rather, (in) the gatekeepers—our political parties." However, the scale of the party gatekeeping failure beggars the oft heard explanation in political science circles that the democratization of candidate selection processes after the civil unrest of the 1960s somehow later opened the door to Trump. That conventional wisdom is ironic in the sense that it blames too much democracy for the failures of Republicans. More importantly, it does not account for the long list of corrosive institutional actions and the related spread of disinformation over decades by Republican elites. While those party leaders and some of their backers, such as surrogates in the "Kochtopus" network, may not have endorsed Trump in 2016, their own legacy of disinformation and erosion of institutional trust left them in no position to stop him or his insurgency once it took hold of the party.

This does not mean that the new Republican Party is one happy family or that its course, much less that of the nation's, are clear. Yet nearly everywhere one looks in the collection of Republican Party surrogates, one sees instability and boundary problems. For example, where are armed militia groups like the Proud Boys, the Boogaloo Bois, or the Patriot Prayer group taking party boundaries? What should we make of the evidence that local police departments and the US military have been infiltrated by far-right white supremacist militias (Levin 2020; Kennedy 2020; Burris 2020; Montgomery 2017)? As party boundaries are changing, the old strategies of "legalized voter suppression" are being supplemented by calls for violence, including attacks on elected Republican officials who do not cleave to the new more radical order.

Indeed, the embrace of violence by party operatives such as the Trump circle of Steve Bannon, Roger Stone, and Michael Flynn, is itself a key warning sign of democracy's threatened collapse. As Nancy Bermeo puts it (2003, 234, emphasis added): "Even profound polarization . . . is never, in itself, a sufficient condition for regime collapse. *Democracies will only collapse if actors deliberately disassemble them and the key actors in this*

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disassembling process are political elites." Beyond those who condone violence in defense of their version of white nationalist democracy, many elected representatives have intensified efforts to dismantle voting rights and to replace secure election provisions with partisan control. This combination of accelerated institutional corruption and the failure of many Republican representatives to condemn and punish violence against state institutions and opponents, signals what Bermeo (2003, 238) refers to as a failure of the party's "distancing capacity."

> By this I mean the strength to distance a party and its members from acts of violence and lawlessness. This distancing involves condemning and prosecuting all those who engage in violence, even when they present themselves as current or potential party allies. The act of distancing serves as an antidote to the contagion of polarization. If parties can muster this sort of strength, they show themselves to be solutions to the problem of disorder and not contributing factors.

Trump and his enablers in the GOP have not just failed to distance themselves from violence, they have at times activity promoted it. During many political rallies, Trump called on his supporters to act violently against protesters and journalists (Cineas 2021; Sullivan 2019). In May 2020, one report found 54 cases of violence linked to Trump's rhetoric that were captured in court documents and police statements (Levine 2020). The chief example of Trump-inspired violence was his invitation to those attending his January 6 rally on the Ellipse Park near the White House to go to the Capitol and "fight like hell." Equally distressing was the action of newly elected Speaker of the House Kevin McCarthy, who gave the congressional security tapes of the insurrection to Fox personality Tucker Carlson in 2023. Carlson aired an edited version of peaceful visitors to the capitol behaving more like tourists than insurrectionists.

Conclusion

We hope that we have offered a friendly corrective to thinking about the nature and role of surrogates in the case of the contemporary US. In our account, the mobilization of online networks by the various enabling factors described earlier threatens the Republican Party's ability to control its own members, much less protect democratic institutions. We want to be clear

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that we do not believe that Trump's rhetoric, alone, is responsible for the increased use of violence in American politics. The organizational dynamics of networked extremism are interactive, with a circular flow of disinformation and support for illiberal actions among online extremist networks, opportunistic media, reactionary political organizations, party operatives, and elected politicians. The result is the movement of online network organizations into the physical world, embodying actions from electing ever more extreme representatives, to the occupation of the national Capitol (Karell 2021).

While Ziblatt's analysis seems to favor parties offering more coherent responses to the conservative dilemma, this may reflect the timeframe of his analysis which is set well before the digital age. It is less clear why Hacker and Pierson hedged the role of digitally mediated surrogates when speaking of the boundaries of institutional gatekeeping and illiberal political ideas in the United States. Our additions to these and other theories of democratic backsliding, suggests that institutional *boundary incoherence might make the conservative dilemma unresolvable for the GOP*. If this is the case, Marjorie Taylor Greene isn't an aberration; she's the future of the GOP. As the cycle of increasing extremism develops, the loudest and most violence prone elements of an increasingly incoherent party draw energy from failed efforts to reach an accommodation.

As networks of Republican surrogates have expanded to include armed militias and conspiracy theorists, and as political divisions are amplified by social media and the push and pull of billionaire donors, the ability of the Republican Party to control principles, core ideas, and even its own members, becomes much more challenging, if not impossible (Sottile 2020). What might that look like in the US in coming years? As party boundary problems lead to a splintering of the Republican Party due to a realignment of its surrogates, a period of instability seems likely. One path might feature relatively anarchic libertarianism and government instability. Another might include a more authoritarian white Christian nationalism.

These strains of the current situation may of course intermingle, along with other developing possibilities. Some of these outcomes will depend on how judicial institutions respond to the coming challenges to democratic integrity. The judiciary has played a role to date in both deciding elections and allowing voting rights standards to erode. Yet it is an open question as to how legal institutions will react to even more serious threats, given that the judiciary has itself been reshaped over decades as part of the longstanding

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Republican minority rule strategy with guidance from Koch organizations and the Federalist Society, which has helped pack the courts with far-right judges, including a majority of the US Supreme Court justices (Vogel 2022).

This progression from conservative dilemma to party dysfunction more generally threatens the legitimacy of institutions and the coherence of public communication spheres. It is increasingly clear that these developments also present risks to the security of many citizens and public officials attempting to assert democratic values. While our account addresses the underlying institutional and communication factors at play in the contemporary United States, we invite scholars of democratic backsliding in both in the US and other nations to add to this account. Similar trends can be found operating in other democracies to different degrees, with the effects on democratic backsliding varying according to types of electoral systems (e.g., a proportional representation system in the US would surely limit the size of a MAGA party) and levels of corruption, among other factors. However, we offer the outlines of our framework as useful for thinking about other cases. At the very least, this analysis should make clear that it is hard to separate the institutional from the technological roots of attacks on liberal democracy in America and elsewhere.

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